With tinted peaks against the tide
Rises in solitary pride,
And glorious in his golden glow
Spurns back the waves that beat below.[9]

So here we find the sage Agastya, the ‘noblest anchorite’, seated ‘high on the top of Malaya’s hill’ on the Mahendra mountain, beside the sea.

But Agastya is no ordinary rishi. Long before Sita’s abduction she and her exiled husband Rama visit a succession of sages in their hermitages, but none as important as Agastya. They find the sage settled on his mountain top, surrounded by the shrines of Vishnu and all the major gods but one – the notable absentee being Lord Vishnu’s rival, Shiva.

Agastya immediately recognises Rama as the incarnation of Vishnu and acknowledges his importance in the cosmic scheme of things by worshipping him as king of all three worlds. He then presents him with Vishnu’s bow and arrows, which Rama later uses to defeat his mortal enemy, the demon Ravana. Agastya also intervenes in that final battle by praying to Brahma to come in on Rama’s side. So Agastya plays a crucial role in Rama’s final defeat of Ravana, which does not explain why he should be held in such high esteem in the Tamil world.

The sage Agastya has many names, one of them being *kurumuni*, the ‘short ascetic’, because by all accounts he was so dwarfish as to be unable to walk comfortably. And that is how he is usually portrayed: as a short, stumpy-legged fellow with a beard and a pronounced pot-belly, holding a yogi’s beads in one hand and a water-pot in the other. Even his proper name takes two forms, one Sanskrit and one Tamil. The etymology of his Sanskrit name is open to debate but the most logical theory is that it derives from *aga*, ‘mountain’, and *asti*, ‘thrower’, because he is the overthrower of mountains. This is how he first appears in